

Madison County Employment and Training Apprenticeship Program for Students with Disabilities

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Introduction

In January 2022, the Madison County Employment and Training Department (MCET) launched a Registered Apprenticeship program specifically for students with disabilities. Madison County is in southwestern Illinois and is part of the St. Louis metropolitan area. MCET is the Workforce Development Board for the region. Since the initial launch of the program, it has now expanded to multiple school districts and employers. Students participating in the apprenticeships have a range of disabilities, including autism, learning disabilities, Attention-Deficit / Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD), seizure disorders, and intellectual disabilities.

Program Development

The apprenticeship initiative grew out of previously existing relationships that MCET had with the Collinsville Superintendent of Schools and the City of Collinsville. Two factors came together to serve as the catalyst for program development. MCET was working with the City of Collinsville to address staffing shortages, particularly at the city-owned Gateway Convention Center. At the same time, Collinsville High School was looking for additional opportunities for students in special education and the Secondary Transitional Experience Program (STEP) program. MCET received an apprenticeship expansion grant from the state in 2021, which they used to address these two simultaneous needs.

These partners developed the apprenticeship program quickly. MCET and Collinsville held their first meeting regarding the program in September 2021. Through MCET's relationship with the City of Collinsville, they developed apprenticeship positions by working with the city to identify specific needs in their workforce. Housekeeping and events support positions were identified at the Gateway Convention Center, along with



(L to R) - IL State Representative Katie Stewart, MCET Director Tony Fuhrrmann, Jamie Lane & Laura Kott of the Gateway Convention Center, Apprentice Maya McDaniel, and Collinsville Mayor Jeff Stehmon at awarding of DOL apprenticeship certificate.

groundskeeping positions in the city's Parks and Recreation Department. The positions for the apprenticeships were standard openings, modified or job carved to meet the needs of the employer, student availability, and US Department of Labor (DOL) apprenticeship standards. MCET worked with the Apprenticeship and Training Representative (ATR) at the DOL Office of Apprenticeship to identify existing Registered Apprenticeships that matched with the positions. DOL approved three Registered Apprenticeship positions by the end of October 2021, with the first group of six individuals beginning their apprenticeships in January 2022.

"When we initiate conversations with employers, as we're looking at developing the apprenticeship, we discuss what common accommodations occur on a job site, how they could be from zero cost up to \$500 depending on what the accommodation is. We talk about things such as restructuring a sequence of job duties, because maybe the way a person processes information is different, and the sequence those duties are done can be changed. Employers are typically very open to that, because a new way to do it, may be a better way to do it."

—Darlene Ladd, MCET



Program Structure

Here is the basic structure of the student apprenticeship program with the City of Collinsville:

- a) **Partners:** The partners in the program are MCET as the apprenticeship sponsor, the City of Collinsville as the employer, and the Collinsville High School STEP Program as provider of Related Technical Instruction (RTI) and support services, along with the Regional Office of Education.
- b) **RTI and school role:** The RTI provided via the STEP program is supported by [Illinois Vocational Rehabilitation Pre-Employment Transition Services](#) funding. The instruction is based on a standard curriculum with modifications specific to the workplace, including soft skills and work rules. In addition to providing RTI, the school also provides external support to the students and communicates with the employer. The Regional Office of Education serves as the liaison between the STEP Program and VR.
- c) **Student recruitment:** The participating students are in their last year of high school, between the ages of 18 and 21. MCET works with the STEP program coordinators and Regional Office of Education to identify students who are appropriate for apprenticeships with the employer.
- d) **Wage increases:** As with any Registered Apprenticeship, there are incremental wage increases to meet DOL apprenticeship requirements.
- e) **WIOA and on-the-job training funds:** Students are enrolled by MCET into Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA) services. Through on-the-job training funds, MCET pays 50% of the wages.
- f) **Competency-based approach:** For measurement of skill acquisition, the apprenticeship uses a competency-based (not time-based) approach, which measures skill acquisition through the individual apprentice's successful demonstration of acquired skills and knowledge, verified by MCET as the sponsor
- g) **Length of apprenticeships:** The apprenticeships generally run for one year starting in August.
- h) **Apprentice schedule:** During the school year, apprentices attend school in the morning for the RTI and participate in the apprenticeship in the afternoon. The students work 20 hours per week during the school year. During the summer break (May to August), they work full-time, which allows them to expand their career pathway by being able to do the entirety of the position.
- i) **Employer mentor:** The employer provides a mentor, with no more than three apprentices per mentor.
- j) **Credential:** At the end of the apprenticeship, the student receives an apprenticeship certificate from DOL.
- k) **Permanent employment:** If the student successfully completes the apprenticeship, they have the option of staying in the position after leaving school.

Initial Issues

When the program was initially implemented, a number of issues arose:

- » There were behavior and disciplinary issues among the initial group of students. Program partners recognized that they should have taken special care to properly match the students with the positions to ensure a good fit.
- » A lack of availability of external job coaching created challenges in providing the students necessary supports. Job coaching cannot be paid for with VR pre-employment transition services funds.



Apprentice Maya McDaniel at work at the Gateway Convention Center.

- » Front-line staff at both the Gateway Convention Center and Parks and Recreation Department were not prepared to job coach, mentor, and train the students, and experienced challenges in how to properly support them.
- » Students, school staff, parents, and front-line staff did not understand the difference between the co-op model that had been used by STEP and apprenticeship.

As a result of these issues, only one out of the initial six initial apprentices completed the program.

First Successful Apprentice

Despite the initial bumps in the road, the first completer, KeShawn Thomas, was hired as a permanent city employee by the Parks and Recreation Department. As part of his groundskeeping position, he now helps train the new apprentices. KeShawn's success helped serve as an example of the program's potential.

News Coverage of KeShawn Thomas's Success as an Apprentice

- » *Collinsville employee honored after completing program for students with disabilities*, KTVI-TV, January 27, 2023
[Story Text](#) | [Story Video](#)
- » [Video of interview with KeShawn's mother](#)

"We encourage students to provide language so that the employer knows how they learn best. For example, 'I'm a visual learner. I learn best by demonstration.' 'I like to practice after you show me.' 'I do not ask questions. I'm not a question asker. You'll need to ask me if I understand. I'm shy and I don't like to ask questions.' That way it gives the employer some clues on how they are going to train the student and be more effective with them."

—Darlene Ladd, MCET



Apprentice Keshawn Thomas (right) with his mentor Michael Dowell (left) at the City of Collinsville Parks and Recreation Department Center.

Strategies for Long-Term Success

To address the issues that arose, MCET, the school, and the city began to hold regular meetings to review the challenges and determine necessary changes for long-term program success and sustainability. Over time, partners made a number of modifications and enhancements to the apprenticeship program:

1. **Improved job matches:** The partners developed strategies to ensure better matches between the apprenticeship positions and students. These included:
 - » having the Regional Office Education Director and Transition Specialist of Madison County become part of the process to assist with job matching
 - » strengthening student engagement in the hiring process, including interviewing with employer staff, providing tours, and providing position demonstrations
2. **Family/student meetings:** The program began holding family/student meetings where partners explained what apprenticeships are, how apprenticeships will continue past the school year, and the apprenticeship's role in the transition to adult services.
3. **Job coaching curriculum:** A local non-profit organization created a *Job Coaching for Success* curriculum for front-line employer staff. The curriculum is designed to empower front-line staff and managers on how to best work with and support apprentices, by acquiring

the necessary skills to successfully assist with job coaching and facilitation of natural supports. The non-profit develops and delivers training and resources to professionals and organizations that support people with disabilities and provides self-advocacy support and training to people with disabilities.

4. **Student handbook:** Partners created a *Student Worker Handbook* with clearly outlined expectations and work rules.
5. **Benefit issues:** The program addressed Social Security benefit issues by providing copies of the Social Security Red Book to families, providing assistance with using the Student Earned Income Inclusion (a Social Security work incentive), and referring families to the *Social Security Work Incentive Planning and Assistance (WIPA)* program for more comprehensive benefits assistance.
6. **Student “Cheat Sheets”:** Students developed Student Cheat Sheets, short narratives that explain to their supervisors how the student learns best and what motivates them on the job.
7. **Round table meetings:** The partners continued with regular round table meetings to ensure ongoing open communication and time to address issues.

Ongoing Program Success and Expansion

“A key piece to the success and the partners, has been the meetings that we’ve held, roundtable meetings where people come into the room with the issues: what’s working and what’s not working. Everybody sits down and tries to go through those issues to try and come up with a solution and make the situation better.”

—Tony Fuhrmann, MCET

After making a series of program changes, all four apprentices in the second cohort completed the program and earned their DOL certification. Two of the apprenticeships were in the Parks and Recreation Department, and two were at the Gateway Convention Center. All apprentices were offered permanent employment after graduation.

A third cohort of Collinsville High School students began apprenticeships in August 2023, with expansion to the city’s Streets Department.

With its initial success, the program has expanded to other high schools. MCET has started an apprenticeship program with Edwardsville High School, with students working as apprentices for the local transit agency, doing bus cleaning. In addition, MCET has partnered with Civic Memorial High School to create an apprenticeship with a private employer, West Start Aviation. MCET is also looking into apprenticeships for students in other businesses, including technology.

Keys to Success of the Apprenticeship Program

The following are keys to the success of the program:

1. **Starting with employer needs:** Success of the apprenticeship starts with identifying employer needs in terms of staffing. Start by assessing positions with high turnover that the employer is having difficulty filling and positions that a Registered Apprenticeship might be a good fit for. In general, the systematic approach to competency development and support in apprenticeships has been shown to reduce turnover.
2. **Building off existing relationships:** In the case of MCET, the program was built off the existing good working relationship between MCET and the city and school district. The city has been a key piece, committed to the success of the program, and willing to work together with the other partners to make improvements.



Apprentice Dylan Rick at the Gateway Convention Center.

3. **Employer flexibility:** Employers' openness about how apprentices complete job tasks, and employers' flexibility with restructuring job duties have been helpful components.
4. **Addressing job coaching issues:** It is important to have either internal or external staff who are skilled at providing necessary supports. MCET addressed the lack of external job coaching by training employer staff on how to best support people with disabilities, with an emphasis on using natural supports. Some other options to consider for job coaching are:
 - » making individuals eligible for Title 1 VR services which, unlike Pre-Employment Transition Services, can pay for job coaching
 - » using available school staff
 - » using a Social Security Plan for Achieving Self-Support (PASS) to pay for a job coach
 - » using funding from the state intellectual and developmental disability agency, if the individual is eligible, and funding for job coaching is available
5. **Providing accommodations guidance:** Sharing guidance and expertise with employers about accommodations should be a core component, including ensuring that the businesses are aware of the [Job Accommodation Network](#) as a resource.
6. **Employer champions:** Employer champions who have a connection to disability issues through their own personal experience (themselves, family members, friends), can be a real asset.
7. **Office of Apprenticeship Support:** The support of the DOL Office of Apprenticeship (OA) or State Apprenticeship Agency (SAA) is critical. For MCET, the support and responsiveness of the ATR at the DOL OA has been an important factor in getting the positions quickly approved as Registered Apprenticeships.
8. **Communication:** Open, honest, and ongoing communication among all the partners is critically important, with a focus on problem-solving and program success.
9. **Family relationships:** Building strong relationships with families is a vital part of student success.
10. **Employer and student support:** Employers must understand they are not alone in this journey, that the partners are there working to support them. Similarly, it is important for students to know that they have wraparound supports.
11. **Staff disability expertise:** Access to staff who have expertise on employment of people with disabilities can be a real asset. In the case of MCET, Assistant Director Darlene Ladd oversees the program. Prior to joining MCET, she worked for 15 years in the employment services programs at a local community rehabilitation provider.

Conclusion

The experience of MCET and its partners demonstrates the viability of Registered Apprenticeship as an option for people with significant disabilities to develop skills, enter the workforce, and embark on a career path. The use of a customized employment approach, through job carving, and through flexibility in positions to match them with the student's capabilities and needs, is a key factor in the ongoing success of the apprenticeship program. In addition, as with any apprenticeship, strong, communicative partnerships are critically important, combined with a commitment by all the partners to resolving issues, and creating a model that provides new employment opportunities for youth with disabilities, while meeting the needs of employers for a skilled and trained workforce.

NEWS COVERAGE

1. [Collinsville city, schools sign Registered Apprenticeship agreement](#), The Edwardsville Intelligencer, November 16, 2021
2. [Madison County apprenticeship programs fulfill pivotal role in developing next generation workforce](#), Illinois Business Journal, October 6, 2022
3. Collinsville apprenticeship program trains students with disabilities for future jobs, KTVI-TV, August 22, 2023

[Story text](#) | [Story video](#)

RESOURCES

City of Collinsville, [Information on Apprenticeship Program and links to materials and videos](#)

REFERENCES

[BBS in Action: Blending, Braiding, and Sequencing: Strategies for Success](#), LEAD Center

Furhmann, T., Ladd, D, Drury, P., Bradford, P. (2023). [Bridging Employment Gaps by Providing Apprenticeship Opportunities for Students with Disabilities](#). PowerPoint Presentation for SHRM Conference.

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ThinkWork!
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ThinkWork! is a resource portal hub at the Institute for Community Inclusion, UMass Boston offering data, personal stories, and tools related to improving employment outcomes for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities.

www.ThinkWork.org